

Chapter

The First Duty of Life — A Promise Made in the Womb



Introduction: What Is the Very First Karma?

In life we perform countless actions — studies, work, family, wealth, reputation. But which action comes before all of these? In this short discourse Acharya Upendra Ji gives a direct answer:

"So the first karma to be done — it is said — is to kindle my fire of knowledge."

And how is this fire of knowledge to be kindled? For that, one needs an awakened Guru in one's life:

"The very first karma, if I am to do anything, is this thought: if I take a life, then in my life there should be my Guru — a Guru who has had realisation, who takes me **from nara to Narayana**, from man to the Divine."

Here, a **Guru who has had realisation** means a Guru who has directly experienced the truth — not merely from books, but through their own sadhana.

The Promise Made in the Womb

Acharya Ji explains that this duty is not a rule imposed from outside. It is the promise every soul made to itself even before birth:

"And this very promise each of us has made to ourselves while in the womb. Read the Garuda Purana sometime."

In the womb, the soul is aware of its past karmas and their consequences. The memory of sufferings such as the

Vaitarani river troubles it:

"I don't like the Vaitarani river and all of that; inside, in the mother's womb, I don't like it. I can understand where I am going there — I have sinned."

In that distress, the soul resolves:

"The first karma I will do — I will once again meet a Guru, I will **attain the Vishnu-tattva**, the Vishnu principle. These mistakes of my past life, I will solve them."

The Memory of Twelve Days

Why, then, is this promise forgotten? Acharya Ji reveals a deep secret — a newborn remembers its past birth for twelve days:

"It is said that when a boy is born, for twelve days he remembers that first thing. After the twelfth day he forgets again in **Vaishnavi Maya**, he gets stuck — what my first duty was, how I was to become the doer."

Vaishnavi Maya — the maya, or illusion, of Lord Vishnu that binds the soul to the world and makes it forget its true identity.

This is also why our tradition sets the time of the naming ceremony as it does:

"That is why the naming ceremony is prescribed on the twelfth day, after twelve days, because for twelve days the child's past birth memory keeps running. Past birth he still remembers, but cannot express."

The Infant's Cry: A Call

Seen this way, a newborn's crying takes on a new meaning. We assume the baby is crying out of hunger, but Acharya Ji says:

"We think it hasn't got milk, hasn't got something else, and that is why it is crying. No — it is crying for this reason: 'Let me go back! Don't leave me. I still haven't found (the Guru). In twelve days I am going to forget again.'"

It is the call of an infant who knows that its resolve is about to be lost in maya.

The Guru's Work Is to Remind

Acharya Ji makes clear that this knowledge is in the scriptures, and seekers ought to know it already:

"Have you read all this in the Garuda Purana, in the Katha Upanishad, or not? You will have done at least that much study. You have been taught this in the Pitru Mukti Shivar, taught in detail."

So the first duty need not be imposed on anyone; the Guru only reminds us of the forgotten promise:

"So my first karma need not be imposed by someone else; you should remember it yourself, by reading the scriptures. Gururji or Acharya Ji only reminds you of what you yourself said your first karma would be — **the doer. I will become the doer.**"

The Four Steps of the True Doer

The resolve taken in the womb is a complete sequence. Acharya Ji puts it in these words:

"So this is the first: I will seek out the Guru — my worthy Guru in this birth. After that, all my karmas, the wrong things I had done in past lives, I will first cut them away. Whatever sins I committed, I will atone for them."

"Only after doing that will I do new meritorious work, something good, and do some tangible work — meaning something the world will see, visible work, tangible work. And by meditating, removing all attachment here, bringing about moksha — the destruction of moha, attachment — I will merge and dissolve."

Seen simply, the sequence is:

- **Seeking a worthy Guru** — finding a realised Guru in this birth.
- **Purifying old karma** — cutting away the wrong deeds of past lives and atoning for sins.

- **Merit and tangible work** — only then doing new good deeds, work that is visible in the world.
- **Meditation and liberation** — erasing attachment through meditation and dissolving into the Divine.

Note how Acharya Ji opens up **moksha** in a simple sense — **moha ka kshaya**, the destruction of attachment. Where attachment ends, there is liberation.

Action Done in Sleep

In the end Acharya Ji speaks a hard yet compassionate truth:

"This was your first karma, your duty. It is the same for every one. This is what is called the **true doer**."

"Whatever you have done leaving this aside, you are still the doer, but right now you are doing it in sleep. You are not risen up, you are not woken up. Till now you are in a state of sleep."

We all do the work of the world, but until this first duty is remembered, all those actions are actions done in sleep.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 The **first karma** of life is to kindle the fire of knowledge — and for that, to have in one's life a realised Guru who leads from nara to Narayana.
- 2 This duty did not come from outside; it is **the promise every soul made to itself in the womb**.
- 3 A newborn **remembers its past birth for twelve days**, then forgets in Vaishnavi Maya — which is why the naming ceremony is held on the twelfth day.
- 4 An infant's crying is not only hunger; it is also a **call at the loss of that resolve**.
- 5 The Guru imposes nothing, but only **reminds us of the forgotten promise**; this knowledge is available in the Garuda Purana and the Katha Upanishad.
- 6 The sequence of the true doer: seeking a worthy Guru, atoning for past karma, merit and tangible work, and through meditation **the destruction of attachment — moksha**.
- 7 All actions done without this first duty are **actions done in sleep** — waking up is the first task.